

# SAKSHI BHALLA

Institute of Communications Research (ICR), University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign

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| EDUCATION                 | <b>PhD in Media &amp; Communications</b><br>University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign<br>Honors: <i>Phi Kappa Phi</i>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         | 2021–present<br>Champaign, IL |
|                           | <b>Master of Science in Statistics</b><br>University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | 2025<br>Champaign, IL         |
|                           | <b>Master of Arts in Linguistics</b><br>Jawaharlal Nehru University<br>JNU Entrance Test: <i>All India Rank 1</i><br>Thesis: <i>Sociolinguistic Profile of Ahirani</i> (a previously-undocumented language spoken in Maharashtra, India)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | 2018–2020<br>New Delhi, India |
|                           | <b>Bachelor of Arts, with Honors in Journalism</b><br>Lady Shri Ram College for Women, University of Delhi                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | 2012–2015<br>New Delhi, India |
| RESEARCH                  | Information environments, Political communication, Methodology                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |                               |
| RESEARCH<br>APPOINTMENTS  | <b>Amazon Inc.</b><br><b>Research Scientist - PhD Intern</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | May–Aug 2026<br>Arlington, VA |
| PEER-REVIEWED<br>ARTICLES | (4) Ray, R., <b>S. Bhalla</b> & H. Taneja. (2026). Fact checkers are seldom used by news users on either side of the partisan divide. <i>Journal of Communication</i> . <a href="https://doi.org/10.1093/joc/jqaf018">doi:10.1093/joc/jqaf018</a><br>(3) <b>Bhalla, S.</b> , M. Nelson & M. Spikes. (2025). Classroom Contexts: Teachers Talk Teaching Media Literacy. <i>Journal of Media Literacy Education</i> . <a href="https://doi.org/10.23860/JMLE-2025-17-2-3">doi:10.23860/JMLE-2025-17-2-3</a><br>(2) <b>Bhalla, S.</b> , R. Ray & H. Taneja. (2024). When news is entertainment: Explaining the persistence of misinformation through the information environment. <i>Information, Communication &amp; Society</i> . <a href="https://doi.org/10.1080/1369118X.2024.2406819">doi:10.1080/1369118X.2024.2406819</a><br>(1) Khan, A., S. Natarajan, & <b>S. Bhalla</b> . (2021). Climate Strikes in Millennial India: Social Capital and “On-Ground” Networks in Digital-First Movements. <i>Communication, Culture &amp; Critique</i> . <a href="https://doi.org/10.1093/ccc/tcab035">doi:10.1093/ccc/tcab035</a> |                               |
| BOOK CHAPTERS             | <b>Bhalla, S.</b> & H. Taneja. (2025). User-defined Repertoires. In Nai, A., Grömping, M., & Wirz, D. (Eds). <i>Elgar Encyclopedia of Political Communication</i> . Edward Elgar Publishing.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |                               |
| OPEN-SOURCE<br>SOFTWARE   | <b>Bhalla, S.</b> <a href="#">breakingnews</a> : Parameter-Efficient LLM Adaptation for Segmenting Broadcast Transcripts. <a href="https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.21863477">doi:10.5281/zenodo.21863477</a>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |                               |

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| WORK IN<br>PROGRESS             | Read All Around It: The Regional Organization of Newspaper Markets<br><i>In preparation</i>                                                                                                                                  |           |
|                                 | Following the News: Polarization and the Networked Structure of Attention<br><i>In preparation</i>                                                                                                                           |           |
|                                 | Complements or competitors? Examining human-AI interactions on Sina Weibo<br><i>In preparation</i> ; with Maggie Zhang                                                                                                       |           |
| AWARDS &<br>FELLOWSHIPS         | Top Paper Prize, International Communication Association                                                                                                                                                                     | 2026      |
|                                 | Illinois Distinguished Fellowship (\$75,000)                                                                                                                                                                                 | 2021–25   |
|                                 | Bart A. Cummings Grant (\$1,200)                                                                                                                                                                                             | 2025      |
|                                 | Political Networks Graduate Student Fellowship                                                                                                                                                                               | 2025      |
|                                 | ICA Political Communication Section Travel Grant                                                                                                                                                                             | 2025      |
|                                 | Methodology Center Summer Institute Scholarship (Full support), Purdue University / National Institute on Drug Addiction                                                                                                     | 2025      |
|                                 | SPARK Award for Promising Graduate Students, American Political Science Association (Political Communication Section)                                                                                                        | 2024      |
|                                 | Local Journalism Researchers Workshop Travel Grant, Duke University                                                                                                                                                          | 2024      |
|                                 | National Center for Supercomputing Applications (750,000 × 2 core hours)                                                                                                                                                     | 2023      |
|                                 | Institute of Communications Research Graduate Travel Grant                                                                                                                                                                   | 2022–2025 |
|                                 | Prime Minister’s Scholarship, Government of India                                                                                                                                                                            | 2012      |
| SELECTED<br>CONFERENCE<br>TALKS | <b>Bhalla, S.</b> (2026). Read All Around It: The Regional Organization of Newspaper Markets. <i>Political Communication Section: Midwest Political Science Association</i> . [Full Paper]                                   |           |
|                                 | <b>Bhalla, S.</b> (2026). Following the News: Polarization and the Networked Structure of Attention. <i>Information Systems Division: International Communication Association</i> . [Full Paper]<br>– <b>Top Paper Prize</b> |           |

**Bhalla, S.**, J. Henrichsen & B. Toff (2026). When Machines Start Writing: Assessing the Impact of Generative AI on Journalism Labor Markets. *Computational Methods Division: International Communication Association*.. [Full Paper]

**Bhalla, S.** (2025). Paper Trails: Place, proximity and spillovers in local news ecosystems. *Political Communication Section: American Political Science Association*. [Full Paper; not presented given travel restrictions]

**Bhalla, S.** & Maggie Zhang (2025). Competitors or Complements? Examining the Effect of Human-AI Interaction on Human-Human Interaction. *Human-Machine Communication Division: International Communication Association*. [Full Paper]

**Bhalla, S.** & H. Taneja (2024). Dissecting Selectivity in a fragmented media environment: A novel approach. *APSA Political Communication Preconference*.

**Bhalla, S.** & H. Taneja (2024). Entwined Realms: Media Contexts and Information Choice. *American Political Science Association*. [iPoster]

**Bhalla, S.**, R. Ray & H. Taneja (2024). When News is Entertainment. *International Communication Division: AEJMC*, Philadelphia, PA. [Poster]

**Bhalla, S.** & H. Taneja (2024). Beyond Preferences: Contextual Influences on News Diets in High-Choice Environments. *Political Communication Division: AEJMC*, Philadelphia, PA. [Poster]

**Bhalla, S.** & H. Taneja (2024). Entwined Realms: Examining Media Contexts and News Choice. *A Computational Turn in Journalism: ICA 2024 Preconference*, Singapore/Virtual.

**Bhalla, S.**, M. Nelson & M. Spikes (2023). Context Matters: Teachers Talk Media Literacy in the Classroom. *Mass Communication Division: International Communication Association*, Toronto, Canada. [Full paper]

**Bhalla, S.**, R. Ray & H. Taneja (2022). Foregrounding contexts in disinformation studies: A study on the failure of fact-checking in India. *What Comes After Disinformation Studies? ICA Preconference*, Paris, France.

Ray, R., **Sakshi Bhalla** & H. Taneja (2022). Fact checkers fail to overcome partisan divides in two of the world's largest democracies. *Political Communication Division: International Communication Association*, Paris, France. [Full Paper]

**Bhalla, S.** (2021). Foregrounding Space and context: A discursive study of fact-checking in India. *South Asia Communication Association: AEJMC*, Virtual.

Ray, R., **Sakshi Bhalla** & H. Taneja (2021). Do fact-checkers overcome partisan divides: An investigation of Indian Twitter users. *International Communication Association*, Virtual. [Full paper]

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|               | <p><b>Bhalla, S.</b> (2018). The Global in the Local: Inter-cultural Translation in the Backdrop of Global Advertising. <i>International Symposium on Linguistics Across Disciplines</i>, Aligarh Muslim University, India. [Full paper]</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |              |
| WORKSHOPS     | <p><b>Bhalla, S.</b> (2025). Following the News: Polarization and the Networked Structure of Attention. <i>PolNet &amp; PaCSS, 2025</i>, Cambridge, CA.</p> <p><b>Bhalla, S.</b> (2024). Diffused News Cultures: Explaining news cultures through spatial relationships. <i>Local Journalism Researchers Workshop</i>, Chapel-Hill, NC.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |              |
| PRESENTATIONS | <p><b>Bhalla, S.</b> (2024). Navigating Narratives: Selective Exposure to Indian Journalists. <i>Social Media and Society in India</i>, Ann Arbor, MI/Virtual.</p> <p><b>Bhalla, S.</b> (2022). How politics and platforms skew media literacy instruction. <i>Institute of Communications Research</i>, University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign.</p> <p><b>Bhalla, S.</b> (2021). Ahirani: A Sociolinguistic Profile. <i>Centre for South Asian and Middle Eastern Studies</i>, University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign.</p> <p><b>Bhalla, S.</b> (2021). Foregrounding Space and context: A discursive study of fact-checking in India. <i>The Great Mediation</i> (University of Chicago).</p> <p><b>Bhalla, S.</b> (2019). The Technological Mediation of Political Rhetoric on Twitter. <i>Mediated Campaigns and Unmediated Politics in Millennial India</i>, Centre de Sciences Humaines, New Delhi.</p> |              |
| INVITED TALKS | <p><b>Bhalla, S.</b> (2025). Classroom contexts: Teachers talk teaching media literacy. <a href="#">Media Education Lab</a>.</p> <p><b>Bhalla, S.</b> (2024). News and Information Consumption in the Contemporary Media Environment: Are Fact-Checkers Enough? <a href="#">Jio Institute Masterclass</a>.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |              |
| TEACHING      | <p><b>Pre-doctoral Fellow</b>, University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• <b>Lead Teaching Assistant:</b> Foundations of Data Curation (CS/IS 598)</li> <li>• <b>Instructor of Record:</b> Audience Analysis (ADV 483)</li> <li>• <b>Teaching Assistant:</b> Data Management, Curation &amp; Reproducibility (IS 477); Intro to Popular TV and Movies (MACS 100); Intro to Advertising (ADV 150)</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | 2021–present |
|               | <p><b>Graduate Student Mentor</b>, URAP, University of Illinois</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Introduced undergraduates to research on media, information and politics.</li> <li>• Jury member, Social Issues &amp; Policy and Social Science &amp; Human Behavior panels, Undergraduate Research Symposium 2025 &amp; 2026.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | 2022–present |

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| OTHER<br>RESEARCH<br>EXPERIENCE | <b>IMEDIA Group</b> , University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign<br><b>Research Assistant</b><br>Examined media literacy approaches used by high-school teachers in Illinois through semi-structured interviews.                                                            | 2021–present<br>Champaign, IL    |
|                                 | <b>Open Markets Institute (Center for Liberty and Journalism)</b><br><b>Student Researcher</b><br>Assisted the Illinois Project team; collected data for multiple research projects.                                                                                      | Jun–Aug 2021<br>Washington, DC   |
|                                 | <b>Indian Council of Social Science Research (ICSSR)</b><br><b>Research Analyst</b><br>Developed surveys and interview protocols, oversaw participant recruitment, and coordinated the project team. Findings published in <i>Communication, Culture &amp; Critique</i> . | Jan–Apr 2021<br>New Delhi, India |
|                                 | <b>Indraprastha Institute of Information &amp; Technology (IIIT-New Delhi)</b><br><b>Research Assistant</b><br>Studied media parallelism and framing of policy discourse across news publications during the General Election of 2019 in India.                           | 2019–20<br>New Delhi, India      |
| ADDITIONAL<br>TRAINING          | Chicago School of Experimental Economics Summer Workshop                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | 2025                             |
|                                 | Methodology Center at Purdue Summer Institute                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | 2025                             |
|                                 | Computational Linguistics Bootcamp, IIT Delhi                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | 2019                             |
|                                 | Short-term course on Role of Media in Conflict and Peace                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | 2014                             |
|                                 | Short-term course on Journalism as a Public Good                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | 2014                             |
|                                 | Short-term course on Film Appreciation                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | 2013                             |
| DATA SCIENCE &<br>TECH          | <b>Languages &amp; Tools:</b> R (proficient), Python (intermediate), HTML/CSS (intermediate), $\text{\LaTeX}$ , QGIS/ArcGIS<br><b>Statistical Modelling:</b> Statistical inference, causal inference, network analysis and spatial econometrics, statistical learning     |                                  |
| SERVICE TO THE<br>DEPARTMENT    | ICR Graduate Student Conference: Organizing Team & Reviewer                                                                                                                                                                                                               | 2023                             |
|                                 | ICR Graduate Student Representative                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | 2023–24                          |
| SERVICE TO THE<br>DISCIPLINE    | <b>Reviewing for annual conferences:</b> International Communication Association (Political Communication, Computational Methods, Journalism Studies, and Human-Machine Communication divisions)                                                                          |                                  |

**Reviewing for journals:** *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications – Nature; Journalism Studies; New Media & Society*

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| IN THE MEDIA              | Interview with Centre for Innovation & Sustainability in Local Media. <a href="#">Q&amp;A with media and politics researcher, Sakshi Bhalla</a> . Also syndicated by <i>Editor &amp; Publisher</i> .<br><br>Report by University of Illinois News Bureau: <a href="#">Mandatory media literacy education in Illinois schools impaired by digital divides</a> .                                                                                                                                                                                                    |                                       |
| NON-ACADEMIC EXPERIENCE   | <b>Thinkstr Consultancy</b><br><b>Campaign Strategy</b> ( <i>Promoted to Senior</i> )                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | Mar 2016–Jul 2018<br>Gurgaon, India   |
|                           | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Spearheaded strategic communication for NITI Aayog (Government of India), including the nationwide launch of digital payments in a <a href="#">100-day campaign across 100 Indian cities</a>.</li><li>• Led the campaigns driving the commercial rollout of UPI (Unified Payments Interface) system and BHIM app, leading to nationwide adoption and digital onboarding.</li><li>• The app achieved 10 million downloads within 10 days of launch, and <a href="#">over 17 million in the first two months</a>.</li></ul> |                                       |
|                           | <b>D. E. Shaw &amp; Co.</b><br><b>Associate</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | Jun 2015–Feb 2016<br>Hyderabad, India |
|                           | Evaluated internal program processes and assisted with implementation strategies across multiple teams, supporting high-volume workflows.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |                                       |
| INTERNSHIPS & PROJECTS    | <b>The Coca-Cola Company (India and Southwest Asia HQ)</b><br><b>Summer Intern</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                | Summer 2014<br>Gurgaon, India         |
|                           | Worked with the Public Affairs and Communication Department; supported corporate responsibility initiatives across Marketing and Public Affairs.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |                                       |
| PROFESSIONAL AFFILIATIONS | Member, International Communication Association<br>Member, American Political Science Association<br>Affiliate, Center for Information, Technology, and Public Life (CITAP)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                                       |
| LANGUAGES                 | Native/Proficient: English, Hindi, Punjabi; Beginner: Ahirani                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |                                       |

Last updated: August 9, 2026